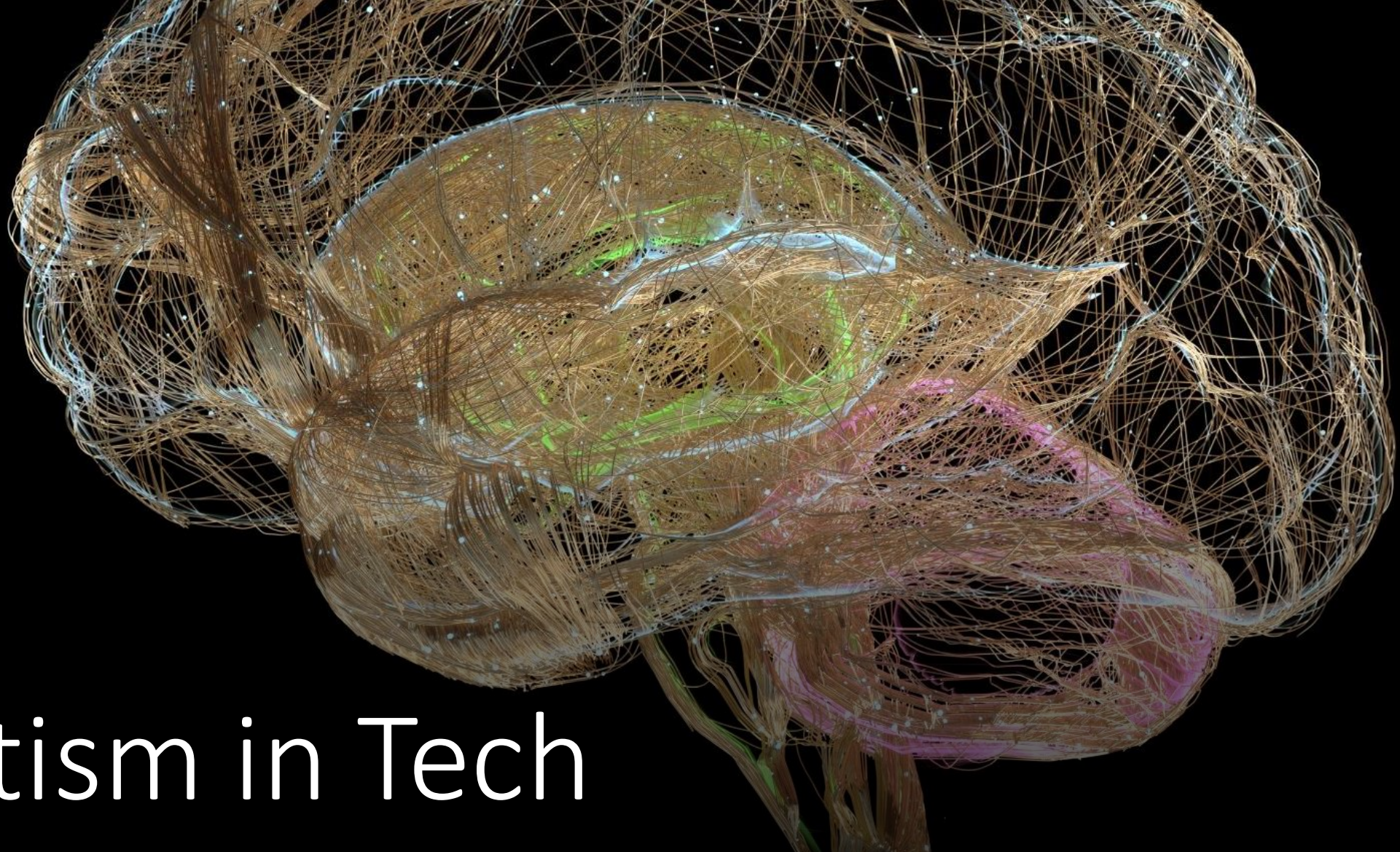
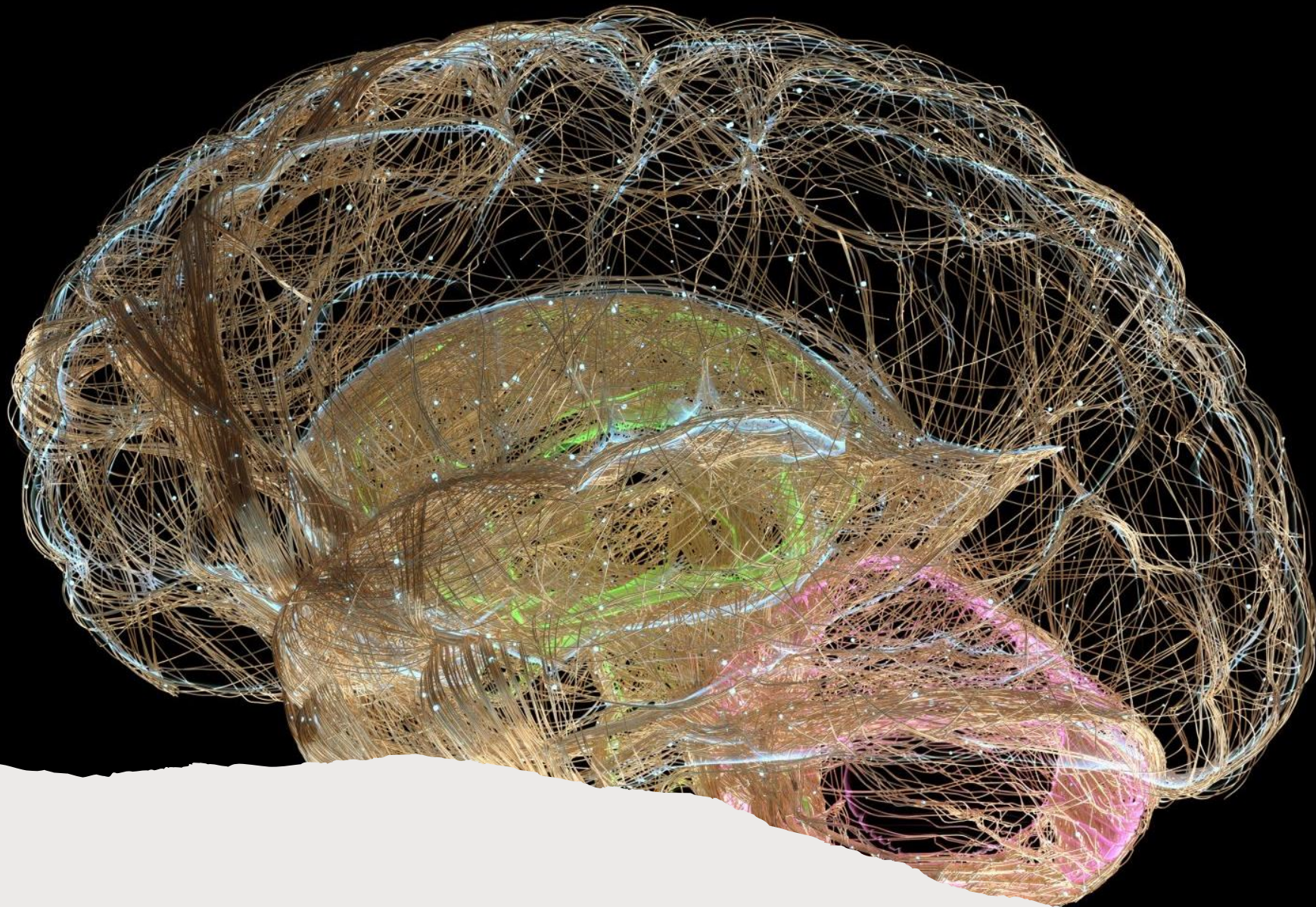




Autism in Tech

@DennieDeclercq // 2023 // AGILE Testing Days



Intro

Dennie

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- >President & IT-Coach DDSoft
- >Microsoft MVP
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Content

> Intro

> Executive Functioning in Tech

> Brain-Response Time in Tech

> Stimuli-Response System in Tech

> Communication in Tech

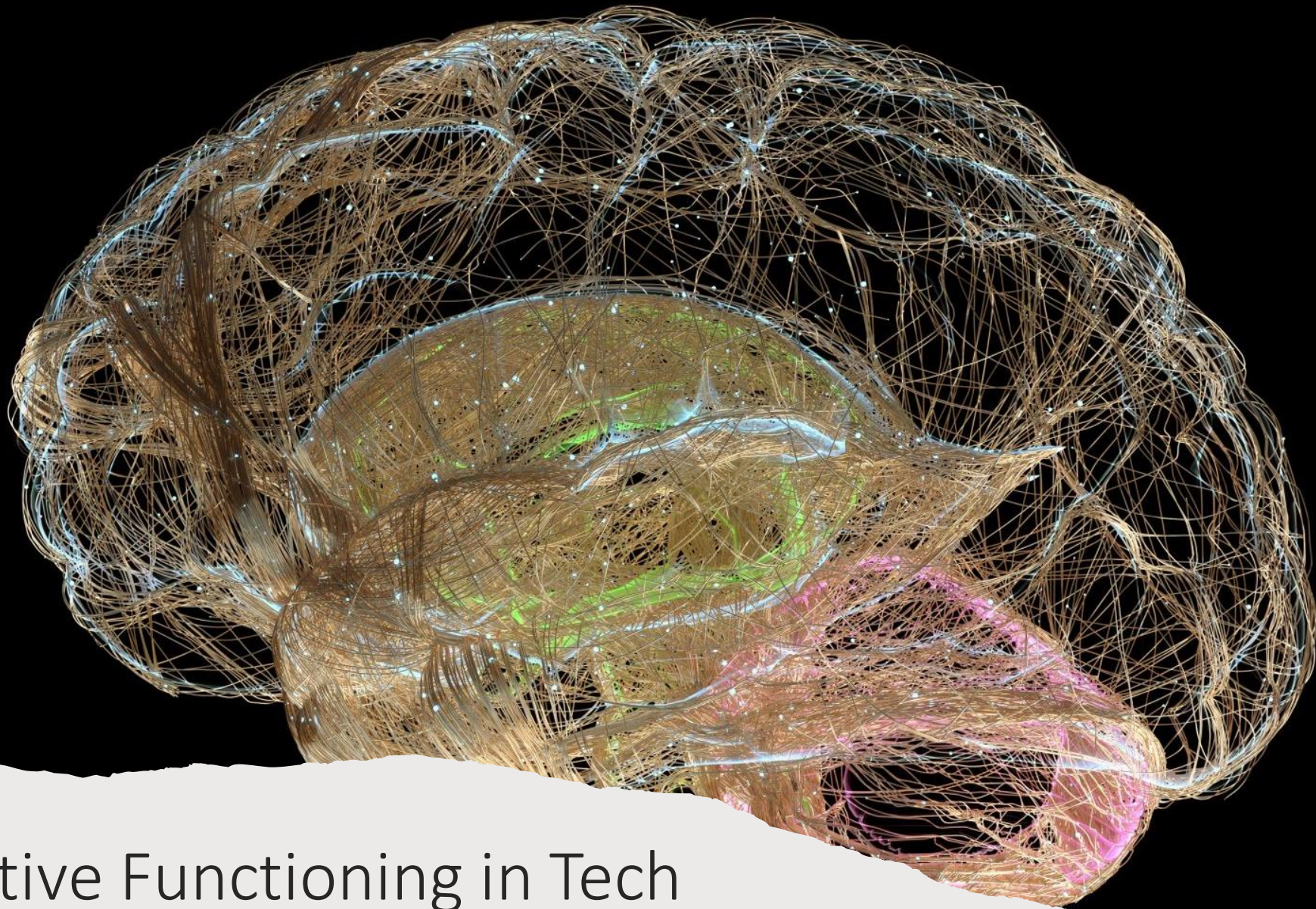
> Outro



Reminder: It's a spectrum after all

- > ASP: Autism Spectrum Profile
- > ASD: Autism Spectrum Disorder
 - > Is A difference a disorder?
 - > Disorder is stigma
 - > Disorder is linked to malfunctioning
- > If (environment == AutismFriendly)=>
 - _ Autism = **Supertalent**
- > **AutismFriendly** == True If =>
 - (Listen, Adjust, Adapt, Empathy, Uniqueness) = True





Executive Functioning in Tech

Executive Functioning

- > Daily living and working activities
- > (Public) transportation
- > Cooking
- > Doing Groceries
- > Your BFF's Birthday party and/ or gift
- > Laundry & Household



Planning/ Structure

- > Which tools are needed?
- > Which resources are needed?
- > How many hours are needed?
- > Is there a sequential order?
 - > (By different teams/ co-workers)



What can help?

- (Printed/ Digital)
 - Scheme's
 - Organigram
 - Availability scheme's
- Reports of previous projects
- Mentoring



Estimating

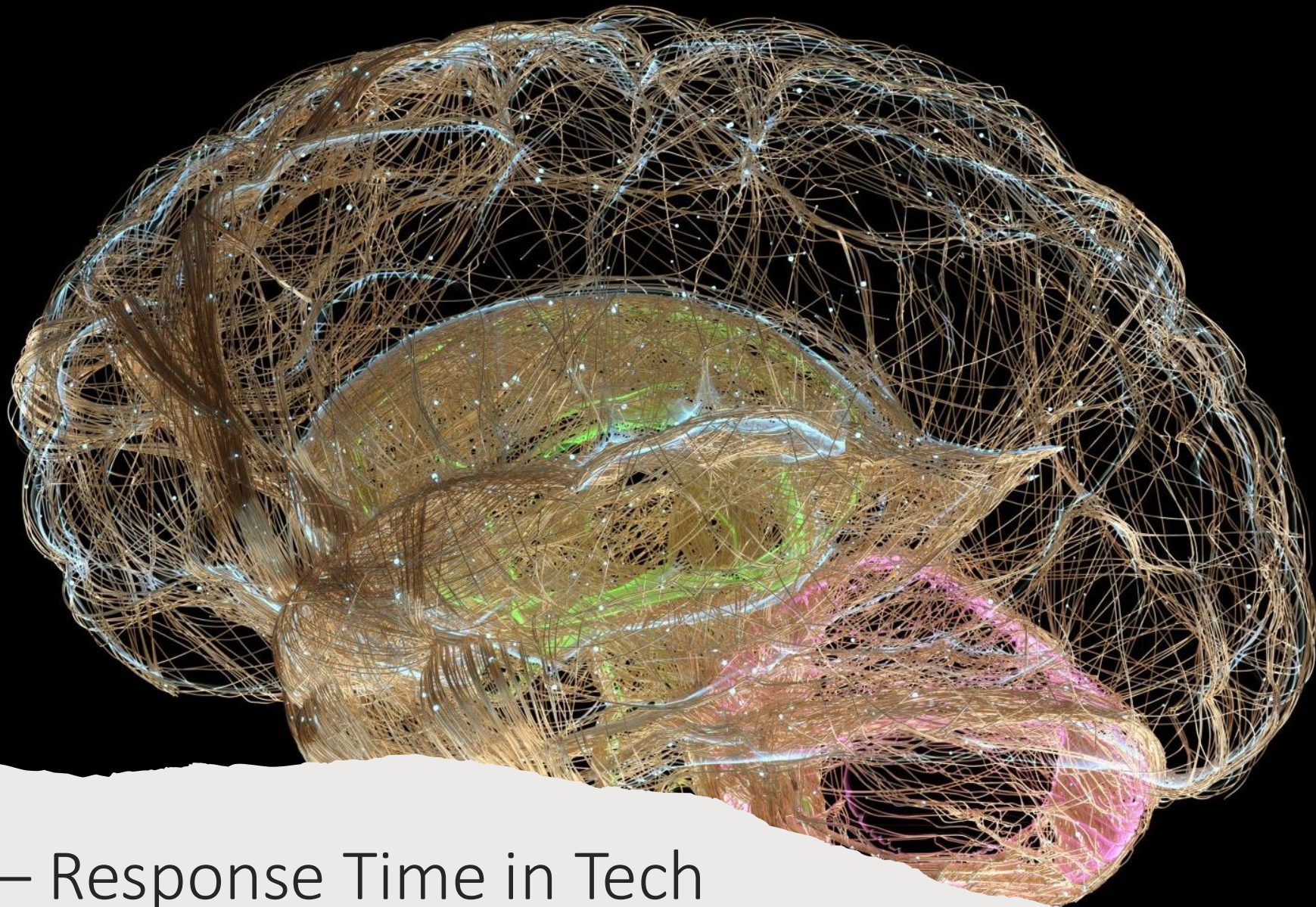
- > How long will X take?
- > How much will this cost?
 - > For the business
 - > For myself
- > Are there consequences?
 - > How big?
- > Which technology?
 - > Clarify: “The right tool for the right job?”



What can help?

- Mentoring
- Team Lead with autism knowledge
- Take time to play with different technologies
- “The proof of the pudding is in the eating”





Brain – Response Time in Tech

Slower Brain – Response time

- > The time it takes to change thoughts or plans
- > Difficulties with “other” ideas
- > Handling positive and negative “surprises”



Thinking takes Time

- > Time to get into Focus Zone/ Flow State
- > Longer thinking, often deeper thinking
- > 10X Steps before on possible consequences



What can help?

- Give time
- Try to limit interruptions
- Appreciate quality over quantity
- Use it!



Unexpected questions and demands

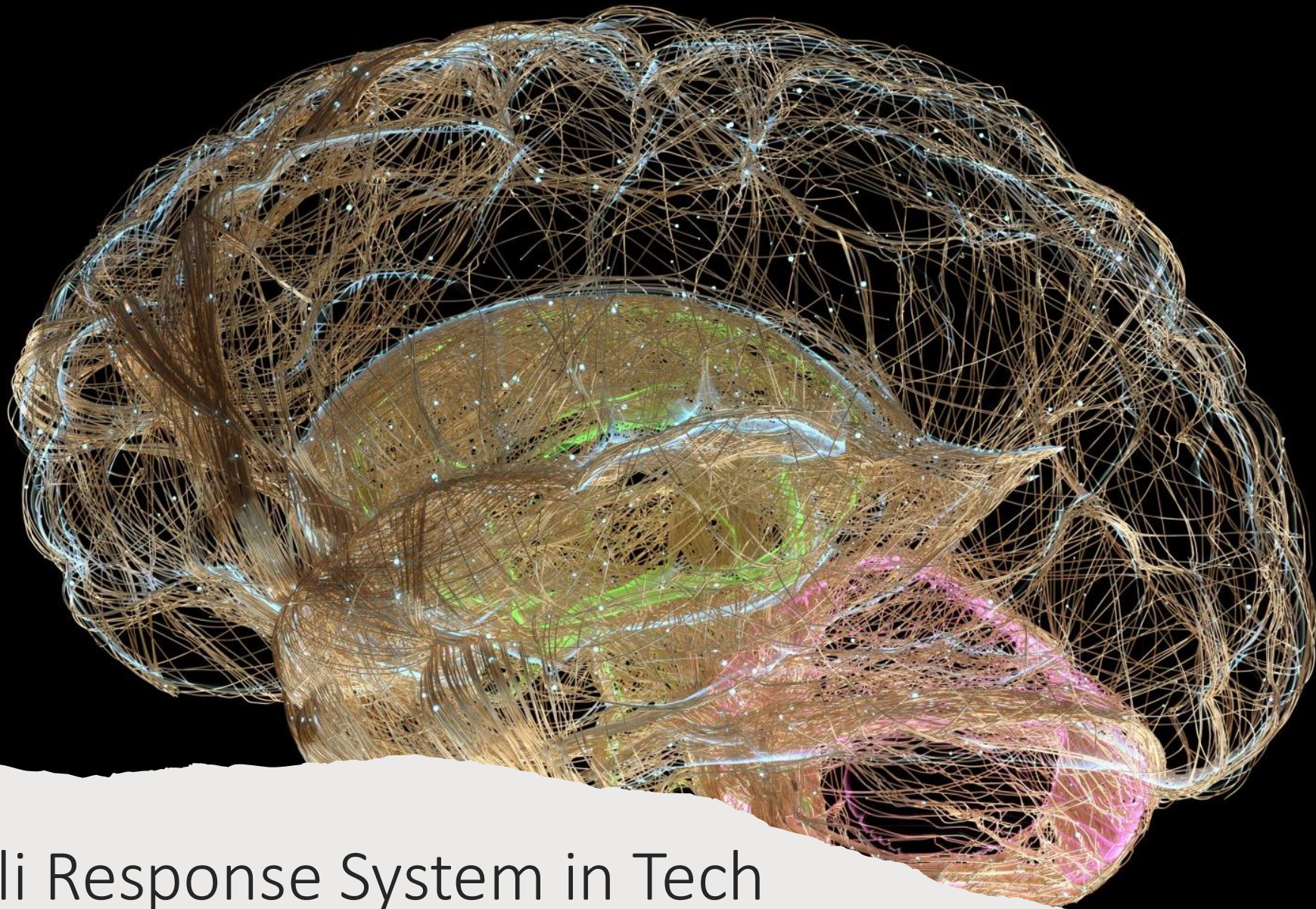


- > Can lead to FREEZE
- > Can lead to absence
- > “Not knowing what to answer”
- > “Answers I’d better never gave”
- > Unexpected Q on prices and permissions are a shame

What can help?

- Be patient
- Give more info than needed
- Protect against misuse without stigmatizing





Stimuli Response System in Tech

Stimuli – Response system

- > Difficult functioning in case of disbalance
- > Overwhelmed by (external) stimuli
 - _Hyper
- > Lack of (external) stimuli
 - _Hypo



Voice & Noise

Hyper

- > Solo-work on projects is a WIN
- > Most of the time speaks silent
- > Less conversations
- > Hard to ask questions



Hypo

- > Meetings and 1-MANY projects are WIN
- > Most of the time speaks loud
- > Talks a lot
- > Asks questions (mostly) often



Movement & Distraction



Hyper

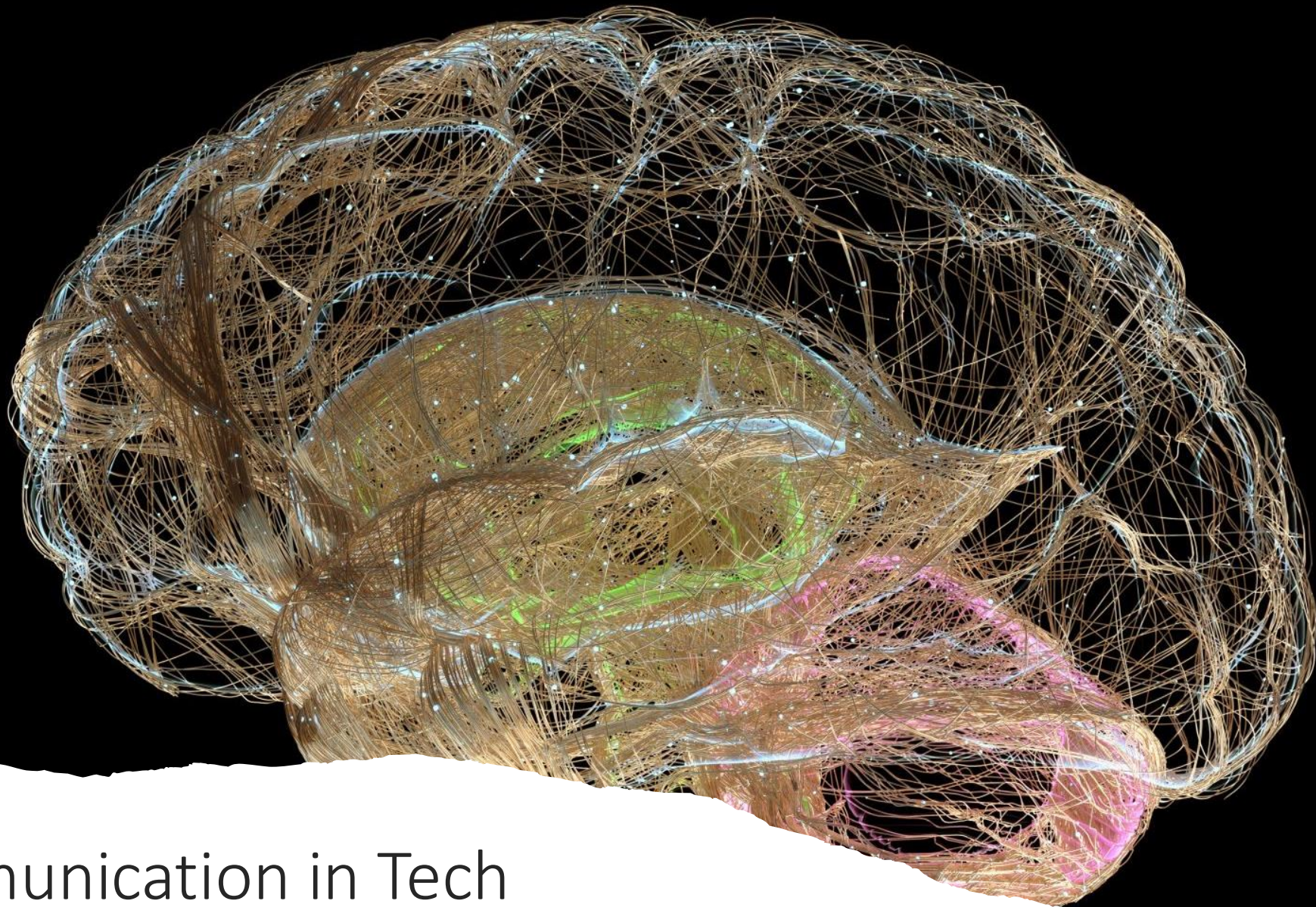
- > Better focus being alone in office
- > Working from home is a WIN
- > Distractions causes stress



Hypo

- > Landscape offices are a WIN
- > Working alone can trigger boredom
- > Distractions causes 'too much talking'





Communication in Tech

Communication

- > Verbal and nonverbal communication
- > Spoken and written communication
- > Limits and borders of the other
- > Clarity and clearness



Mail, Phone or Videocall

- > Written text (mail, app-services) can come “hard”
- > Phone calls can feel uncomfortable
- > Who talks to who?
- > Which is the conversation starter?



What can help?

- Plan phone calls
 - (ex. Dennie's dad)
- Text before calling
- Listen if conversation start with a “word storm”
- Video calls can be a win.
 - But focus on nonverbal comm.



Too strict, too vague or just good



> How much info is needed?

- > About a project
- > About a customer
- > About your own (mental) state?
- > About the software stack - choices

> How much info you share?

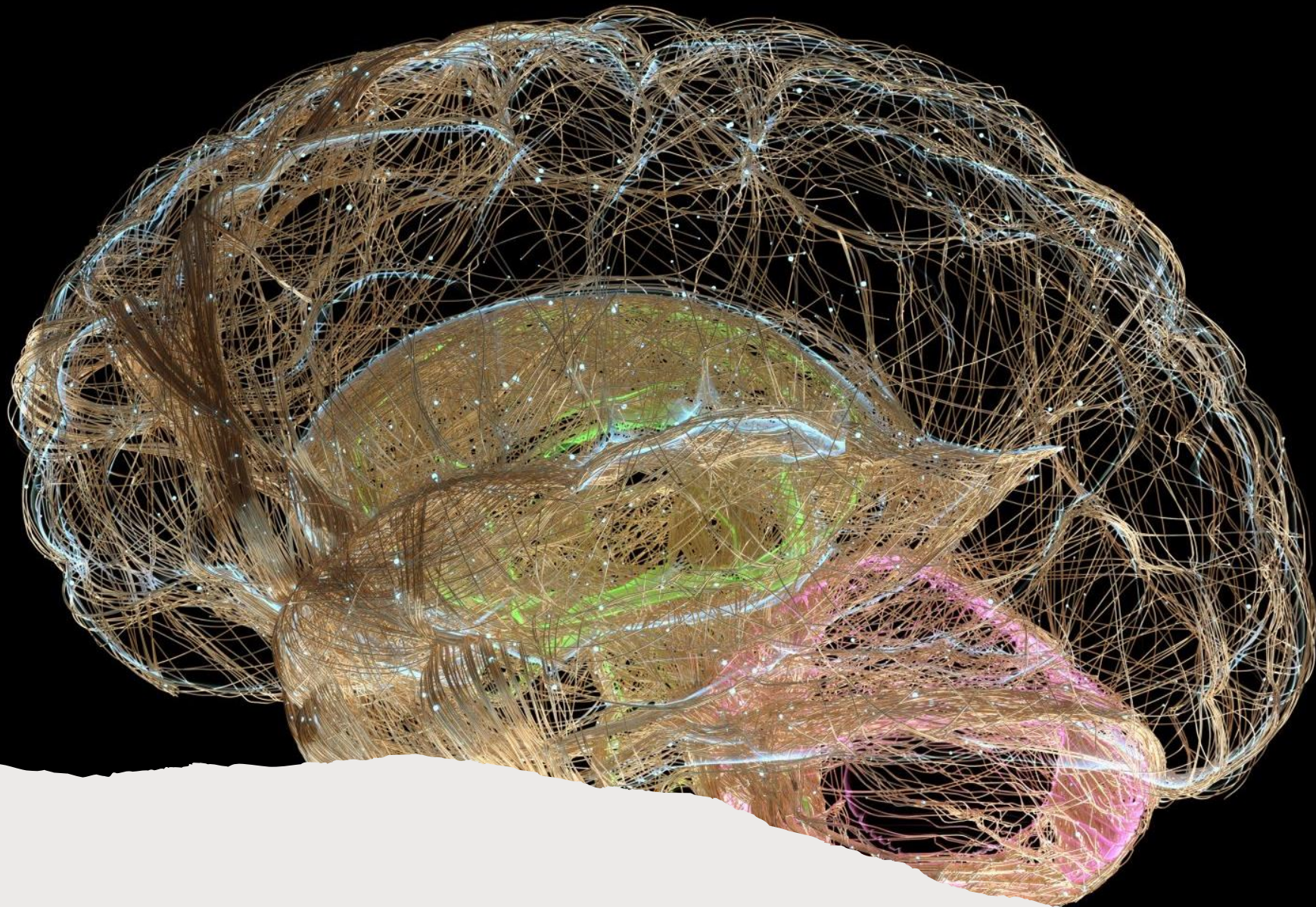
> As a ASP person:

- > Do you dare to ask help, assistance clarity

What can help?

- Be clear and consistent
- Reasoning is very important
- If ASP person asks 'strange details' => don't be surprised





Outro

Recap

- > We talked about autism in Tech (roles)
 - > Executive Functioning
 - > Stimuli-response system
 - > Brain-response time
 - > Communication
- > Explanation, individual approach, taking time, indicating borders – limits – and choices have a big impact



Thanks // Q&A

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